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Time is a game played beautifully by children.
— *Heraclitus*

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Shooting in Juhu is a warning for Mumbai

THE BULLETS that shattered the calm in Mumbai's Juhu on Sunday, when assailants opened fire at actor Tiger Shroff, injuring his driver and a bystander, have also underlined a question mark on the city's preparedness to deal with a new, yet dangerously familiar, threat to law and order. In the two years since the firing outside actor Salman Khan's house was connected to the Lawrence Bishnoi gang, several other incidents including, notably, the killing of former Maharashtra minister and NCP leader Baba Siddique in Bandra in 2024, have been linked to the outfit. The shootings — including the firing outside filmmaker Rohit Shetty's home in Juhu in February — and threats and extortion calls reportedly received by other film personalities are a chilling reminder of the years when Mumbai's underworld held the city hostage. The quick apprehension of three suspects in the latest shooting is welcome, but the recurrent attacks raise disquieting questions.

To begin with, how can these crimes be properly investigated if the Mumbai Police's access to the alleged leaders of the gang, Lawrence Bishnoi (lodged in Sabarmati Central Jail in Gujarat) and Anmol Bishnoi (currently in Tihar Jail in Delhi), is made difficult? Repeated attempts to obtain physical custody of the duo by Mumbai Police have evidently failed, with the Ministry of Home Affairs orders barring investigative agencies from taking the brothers out of jail "for any purpose". The second question concerns what Mumbai Police is doing to reassure the film industry, which is a soft target for organised crime. An attack on a film personality guarantees publicity and can amplify the psychological impact of the threat. The police must make it clear to industry figures that threats and extortion calls will be taken seriously and that those who report them will receive protection. The third and more fundamental question concerns governance in Mumbai. The claims of good governance made by the three-party Mahayuti government, which has all too frequently been preoccupied by internal friction, turf battles and one-upmanship, cannot be insulated from questions about whether the state is able to prevent organised crime from regaining a foothold in the city.

Mumbai is a long way from a return to the dark days of the 1990s, when gang violence and extortion were an almost routine feature of the city's life — that is precisely why the recent incidents must not be dismissed as aberrations. The guilty must be brought to book, and the institutional gaps that allowed the threat to come to the fore must be addressed.

Meta's open-weight gambit, AI's global play

META'S RELEASE of Muse Spark Open, a model designed for coding and tasks that require AI agents to work over extended periods, marks an attempt to regain lost ground in the race for open-weight artificial intelligence. Unlike closed models, whose parameters remain under patent, open-weight models make them available for others to download, run and adapt, subject to the terms of their release. This gives developers and businesses greater control over how they use AI. Muse Spark had remained proprietary since its debut in April, but given China's growing heft in the open-weight field, the American tech behemoth has now presented its open-weight version, calling it the most capable of its kind to come out of the US. This underscores a shift in the AI race: The contest is no longer only about which country can build the most powerful proprietary model, but about whose open-weight model becomes the default for developers everywhere to build upon.

The commercial stakes are equally significant. Open-weight models offer a potential way to reduce costs, making self-hosting realistic for firms that cannot afford frontier-scale hardware. They can also give users greater freedom to apply AI in areas where restrictions imposed by proprietary models may prove limiting. This is particularly crucial in cybersecurity, where AI can be used to identify vulnerabilities, and develop defences. For Meta, Muse Spark Open is an effort to keep American AI models competitive in a market where affordability and adaptability may matter as much as technological prowess. The country whose models become the preferred tools of developers worldwide could shape not only the future direction of AI, but also the commercial ecosystem and technical standards that govern it. Going by benchmark results, American developers still have some ground to make up. On Terminal-Bench 2.1, a test of how well AI agents complete coding tasks in a terminal, China's Kimi K3, GLM 5.3 and Qwen3.8 scored higher than Muse Spark Open.

The path ahead is not without hazards. Open weights can encourage innovation and reduce dependence on a handful of AI providers, but they can also make powerful capabilities harder to monitor once models are widely distributed. Released weights cannot be recalled, making ease of access a double-edged sword. For Washington and Beijing, the challenge is to advance competitive AI ecosystems with safeguards in place. Ultimately, leadership will depend on building systems that developers trust, businesses can afford and society can use responsibly.

Measure time, but let lunch hour be an illusion

TIME", REMARKED Ford Prefect in *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*, "is an illusion. And lunchtime doubly so." The line from Douglas Adams's masterpiece has been quoted by generations of young people, as they discover the joys of philosophy, science and the philosophy of science through a sci-fi comedy. Even if Prefect was right, the illusion is powerful. Getting the "real time" wrong can have pretty serious consequences. In the quest for temporal accuracy, the time lords have decided to grant the world a "leap hour".

The quest for accuracy in measuring time is not merely the province of obsessive bosses. For the physicist and the computer engineer, the difference of even a few fractions of a second can cause problems for experiments and software that the digital world runs on. Subtle shifts in the Earth's rotation have, since at least 1955 and the advent of atomic clocks, caused scientists to introduce ad hoc "leap seconds" — the more common "leap day/year" is more than two millennia old. Last week, delegates from 69 countries to the International Bureau of Weights and Measures voted in France to do away with leap seconds and collect wayward moments into a "leap hour".

There are sound reasons for the shift: The risk to computer systems is lower. That said, there was something mystical about the uncertainty of the most certain measuring devices, the drama of a second gained and lost. Fortunately, lunchtime, at least, remains an illusion more subject to appetite than the clock.

Bending towards bold reform: IDBI stake sale, 26-year arc of governance



N K SINGH

HAS PRIME Minister Narendra Modi's governance brought about winds of change? Modi has just commenced his 26th year in public office. The IDBI strategic disinvestment, the largest FDI in India's financial sector, carries a broader significance. The cabinet's decision to divest it to a private entity, Fairfax, is a major step toward improving the efficiency of financial intermediation. It could signal lower capital costs. Even so, it will be a long haul.

The arc of capital reform has come full circle: From nationalising private banks to privatising a national bank. This matters because India's cost of capital remains above that of ASEAN peers, weakening competitiveness. Within the domestic regulatory framework, the legacy burden of the cash-reserve ratio, statutory liquidity ratio and priority-sector lending circumscribes optimum credit allocation. A banking system steeped in PSU culture may not consistently give Indian entrepreneurs capital at a globally competitive cost.

In the past, I have lamented the tardy pace of reforms in India's factors of production (land, labour, capital) despite the big changes of 1991. Post-Independence India was shaped by Fabian Socialism and a deep distrust of private capital. The nationalisation of 14 banks in 1969, and six more in 1980, brought 91 per cent of banking under public control. Political lending and recurring bad-loan crises were the deleterious features of this model.

I recall the mixed opinions when private banks in India were nationalised. That was an era of political dependence on left-oriented policies. The much-applauded far-reaching economic reforms of 1991 bypassed the structural changes needed in other factors of production. It took PM Modi's leadership to implement the four labour codes. Land and agricultural reforms have encountered political constraints. IDBI's divestment builds on the asset monetisation model launched during the pandemic.

The matrix of Modi's governance is captured by Lee Kuan Yew's maxim: "Policy is implementation; implementation is policy." Six Cs stand out clearly in the model rehearsed in Gujarat but refined and implemented in Delhi.

First, consistency. Modi inherited a state recovering from the Bhuj earthquake and recast governance from an administrator-oriented approach to one centred on enabling. Vibrant Gujarat (2003) signalled investor confidence through "minimum government, maximum governance". In Delhi, that focus on delivery has powered Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, UPI, Swachh Bharat, Ayushman Bharat, IBC, GST, DBT and PRAGATI.

Second, continuity or the capacity to judge what works amongst programmes he inherited, while recalibrating them for greater development. Aadhaar has been scaled into one of the world's largest digital public infrastructures. VB-G RAM G builds on MGNREGA, retaining its statutory employment guarantee while raising it from 100 to 125 days and linking employment more closely to durable rural assets, livelihoods and infrastructure.

Third, creativity. Embracing cutting-edge technology is an attribute of Modi's leadership and a true expression of Schumpeterian "creative destruction". PRAGATI uses digital technology to connect him directly with secretaries and chief secretaries and resolve stalled projects. Oversight was centralised; execution decentralised. With Jan Dhan and UPI, Modi revolutionised large-scale benefit delivery. He pushed PSUs and PSBs to shed the habits of a bygone era. There can be no creativity without audacity. But every audacious decision carries risks. In Gujarat, the Sardar Sarovar canals advanced a dream deferred for decades. As chairman of the 15th Finance Commission, I watched Narmada water pumped against gravity into Saurashtra and Kutch. Resolve, engineering and sustained execution justified the slogan, "Modi *hai to mumkin hai*." Viksit Bharat 2047 extends that horizon to the nation.

> The fiscal glide path has survived a pandemic and more than halved the central fiscal deficit. Under the IBC, gross NPAs fell from 11.2 per cent in 2018 to 1.8 per cent in 2026

Fourth, sustained efforts to persuade and build a consensus. The Nobel prizes to Daniel Kahneman and Richard Thaler recognised behavioural economics and "nudge" theory. Modi has mastered both, reaching people through *Mann Ki Baat*, Swachh Bharat and *Beti Bachao Beti Padhao*. The GST Council is a unique experiment in pooled sovereignty: Modi persuaded states to vest their taxation sovereignty in a body of which they are members. This cooperative federalism could extend to state-level regulation, audit and procurement, with the Finance Commission as constitutional anchor for sharing best practices. Decisiveness need not shade into authoritarianism.

Fifth, commitment. The fiscal glide path has survived a pandemic and more than halved the central fiscal deficit. Under the IBC, gross NPAs fell from 11.2 per cent in 2018 to 1.8 per cent in 2026. Inflation targeting anchored monetary policy. For the first time, effective capital expenditure (4.4 per cent of GDP) exceeded the fiscal deficit (4.3 per cent). PM Gati Shakti maps over Rs 100 lakh crore of infrastructure across 16 ministries. Make in India 2.0, PLI and the Semiconductor Mission drove structural reform. Solar capacity surpassed India's Paris climate pact targets five years early.

Sixth, calibration. The old world order has dissolved, and multilateralism is being displaced increasingly by plurilateral, if not bilateral, transactional mercantilism. The challenge remains of harmonising the past with the emerging new order. Nine FTAs signed by the Modi government cover 38 countries. The G20 and BRICS presidencies gave the Global South and Africa a greater voice.

As our aspirational electorate seeks new promises, what are the challenges? Five priorities will shape Viksit Bharat. First, faster growth through productivity, competitiveness and adherence to the fiscal glide path. Second, completing factor-market reform, with financial intermediation efficient enough to bring our cost of capital on par with international levels. Third, a modern legal architecture that enables faster dispute resolution, stronger contract enforcement and investment protection. Fourth, manufacturing beyond assembly, backed by efficient power, logistics and urban infrastructure. Fifth, quality jobs, skilling and R&D, balancing AI adoption with job creation.

The most proximate reason for writing this piece is the broader reforms to enhance financial intermediation. This is laudable. However, one should not arrive at premature conclusions about the privatisation of public-sector banks. We know one swallow does not make a summer. But we also know that once a firmly locked door is even slightly opened, the winds of change can make it ajar over time. Could IDBI be an example of these winds of change?

The writer was chairman, 15th Finance Commission

Independence of ECI cannot survive on assurances alone



D RAJA

INDIA'S DEMOCRACY was not a gift to its people by a benevolent ruler. It was won through a long and arduous struggle against colonial rule, a struggle in which millions participated and countless freedom fighters sacrificed their lives. When India became independent, the Constituent Assembly, under the leadership of B R Ambedkar, gave this democratic aspiration an institutional form. The Constitution established India as a sovereign democratic republic and guaranteed universal adult suffrage. Many democracies, including the US and European countries, took generations to overcome restrictions based on property, race, gender and social status. India began its constitutional life with universal adult franchise.

The Narendra Modi government is systematically weakening the institutions that sustain democratic accountability. Its understanding of democracy appears to begin and end with winning elections, while treating independent institutions, opposition parties, dissenting citizens and public scrutiny as obstacles to be overcome. The Election Commission of India (ECI) has come under unprecedented scrutiny. Article 324 vests in the ECI the superintendence, direction and control of the preparation of electoral rolls and the conduct of elections to Parliament, state legislatures, and the offices of the President and Vice President. This mandate demands independence, impartiality and public confidence.

Elections have increasingly been distorted by the enormous advantages enjoyed by the BJP through money power, the use of state machinery and the weakening of institutional checks. The electoral bonds scheme, struck down by the Supreme Court in 2024, exposed how an opaque system of funding had enabled the ruling party to benefit disproportionately from anonymous donations. The 2023 law governing the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners marked another setback. It replaced the Supreme Court-prescribed selection arrangement with a committee dominated by the executive, giving the government of the day decisive influence over the selection.

The independence of the Election Commission cannot survive on assurances alone when the executive it is supposed to scrutinise exercises such control over the selection of its leadership. Questions about the institution's credibility have also been raised by former Election Commissioners. The BJP's response has not been to restore confidence through transparency and accountability, but to demand unquestioning acceptance of the institution's decisions.

The Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has brought these concerns to a dangerous new level. More than 13 crore names have been deleted during the SIR exercise. The fundamental question is simple: In a democracy, voters are supposed to elect their rulers, not the other way around. When millions of names disappear from electoral rolls, the burden of proof cannot be shifted onto citizens who are already disadvantaged. Nor can the ECI expect the public to accept its assurances without transparent procedures, verifiable records and independent scrutiny. The controversy over unilateral changes to Form 6 has only deepened the crisis of confidence.

The scale of the Modi government's anxiety about this movement is evident in the response to peaceful protest. Delhi was fortified with barricades and an overwhelming deployment of security personnel. Students and youth who gathered to demand Gyanesh Kumar's resignation were detained, manhandled and beaten by Delhi Police, a force under Union Home Minister Amit Shah. Journalists covering the demonstrations were also detained, drawing condemnation from press-freedom organisations. The INDIA bloc, with the active participation of the Left, has joined a growing people's movement to restore public confidence in the democratic process. This movement must go beyond demanding the resignation of Gyanesh Kumar. It must press for independent and transparent appointments to the Election Commission, a review of electoral-roll deletions, accountability for arbitrary exclusions, transparency in political funding and meaningful electoral reform. It must also advance the demand for a return to paper ballots, reflecting the widespread distrust of electronic voting systems among sections of the electorate.

Gyanesh Kumar must resign, electoral reforms must follow, and the people's right to determine their own destiny must prevail. The movement will continue.

The writer is general secretary, CPI

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Parental consent makes right to internet conditional



VIKRAM RAJ

THE SUPREME Court's October 15 order has been read, rightly, as a defeat for the social media ban. Justices J B Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran held that access to the internet is a fundamental right that children share "irrespective of their age", that a blanket restriction is no answer, and that keeping children offline because platforms fail to remove abuse material "would be to mistake the victim for the problem". Having spent months arguing against Karnataka's under-16 proposal, we can take the win. But look at what the order, and everything around it, quietly agrees on.

On September 28, a bench led by the CJI heard a second petition by the same alliance. It asked the Centre to examine whether anyone under 18 should need a parent's consent to open an account, and the Solicitor General said the Data Protection law's parental-consent model could be adopted in some other law to do it. The Pardiwala bench recommended "parental consent, guidance and oversight" with a dedicated child mode. The petitioner wants it, the government wants it, both benches want it.

The Data Protection Rules say a platform may not process a child's data without verifiable consent from a parent, and that it must confirm the parent is an adult using "reliable details of identity and age", with a government-notified digital locker as one route. For every user who is a child, an adult must then produce government-grade proof of who they are and how old they are. The platform keeps enough to prove it did this, and the child's account is tethered to a named adult's identity record for good.

Read the Pardiwala order's own warning against that. Age-based restrictions, the bench wrote, "inevitably, always require identifying and ascertaining the age of each and every user, continuous collection and monitoring of sensitive data and an overall disproportionate risk of misuse and surveillance". Every word applies to parental consent as the Rules define it. The only difference from a ban is that the child gets in, once an adult has been identified on her behalf. Family mediation deepens inequalities where the household already controls the device, and ASER 2024 shows rural girls of 14 to 16 already own fewer phones and use social media less than boys. A consent regime makes the father the platform's compliance officer. For a girl in a conservative home, a queer teenager, a child being abused by the very adult who holds the Aadhaar, "parental oversight" is not a safeguard. It is the problem with a legal mandate behind it. Platforms can live with this, and the state gets a verified identity layer without ever having to pass a law that says so. And the people it costs, children and the adults tied to their accounts, were never in the room.

The order leaves a harder route open, which is why nobody has taken it. The bench named it in passing, accounts private by default, no contact from unknown adults, controls on advertising to children. These are obligations on the platform, which the Centre can impose under the IT Rules. Where age must be known at all, the check can return one bit, over or under, and nothing else. And the court has asked the Centre to report on what tools platforms actually use to detect and remove abuse material. That report is the test. If the answer is thin, the remedy is penalties for the platform, not papers from the parent.

The writer is associated with Internet Freedom Foundation

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40 YEARS AGO

October 20, 1986


INDIAN EXPRESS
India, Thailand differ on Kampuchean issue
Accord on wide areas of trade

The Kampuchea question

INDIA AND Thailand differed in their approach to bringing about a solution to the Kampuchean problem, though there were "some points of commonality" on the issue. The difference of opinion was reflected during the talks Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi had with his Thai counterpart, Gen Prem Tinsulanonda, and later in their banquet speeches.

Congress-I leader shot dead

TERRORIST ACTIVITIES in Punjab claimed the life of a Congress-I leader, Prakash Chand Thuliwal, while the wireless network of the state police was jammed by a pirate transmitter for the third time in a fortnight in Amritsar district in the past 24 hours. Thuliwal, a spare parts dealer in Bagha Purana, Faridkot district was shot dead in his shop.

USSR expels 5 US diplomats

FIVE US diplomats have been ordered to leave the USSR for "activities incompatible with their official status", a Foreign Ministry statement announced. The statement, which said the ministry had protested to the US embassy, named four embassy officials in Moscow and a consular officer in Leningrad.

The living dead

IN AN act of criminal negligence, three patients at Osmania General Hospital were presumed dead and dumped into the mortuary compound. Consequently, one of the three died, and a hue and cry was raised by doctors of the forensic department who discovered the other two alive in the mortuary. They were shifted back to the hospital. Investigations by the *Indian Express* revealed that the three were allegedly thrown into the mortuary compound by two sweepers.